personally: They have their positive qualities and their negative ones; they perform well in some circumstances and poorly in others. They are neither good nor bad, but subject to influence.

That's why you cannot make a good history out of recent events; you know it too well!

In every discipline, the phenomenon is the same. In school, the complexities of real life are removed so that students can be tested on set groups of memorable, learnable, understandable bits of stripped-down, sanitized "knowledge."

That is why more education does not always lead to more success in the real world, and why we do not recommend too much "education" for children. It could be counterproductive. The better you get at handling the artificial world of academia, the worse you may do at solving the real world's infinitely nuanced challenges.

Problem solving in the academic world typically involves a part of the brain—but only a part of the brain. It is the "rational" part, the part that remembers facts, reads, writes, and connects the dots. That is the skill measured by the SAT tests, for example. They are tests of "scholastic aptitude." And they are pretty good at it. If you are able to do the kind of tricks the tests require, you'll be able to handle the kind of work they give you in school.

But life sends very different tests your way. Life's tests involve many, many more variables—so many that your "rational" mind is frequently overwhelmed. The human face, for example, is capable of hundreds, or thousands, of different expressions. Some people seem better able to read these messages than others. In the world of textbooks, other people scarcely matter. You read. You write. You check the boxes. But once you get into a workplace, you are confronted with faces—and an entirely new test. How well can you get along with others, motivate them, lead them?

In school, tests are anticipated. In real life, you never know when you will be tested. You never know what you will be tested on. And even when you are in the middle of an important test, you often don't know it.

In some careers—science, engineering, or accounting, for example—you are able to apply the body of knowledge you picked up in school. In many more, you're not. In most careers, you have to learn on the job a new body